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California Assembly majority leader gets ousted in major leadership shakeup

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Author: Andrew Sheeler, The Sacramento Bee | Section: capitol_alert | 659 Words
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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

RIVAS SHAKES UP THE ASSEMBLY LEADERSHIP

Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas, D-Hollister, announced a radical change to Assembly leadership Tuesday night that included the ouster of Assemblyman Isaac Bryan, D-Los Angeles, as majority leader.

In a statement, Rivas thanked Bryan for his “exceptional work during my transition into the office of speaker.”

Assemlbywoman Cecilia Aguiar-Curry, D-Winters, will take over for Bryan, while Assemblyman Jim Wood, D-Healdsburg, replaces Aguiar-Curry as speaker pro tempore.

Wood, who departs the chamber next year to care for his aging mother, said in a statement that he looks forward to “working alongside the speaker to make sure the voices of Californians are heard in Sacramento.”

According to Politico, Bryan had talked himself up as a strong second-in-command of the lower chamber. In a statement to Politico following the shakeup, he observed that Black Californians “now see no representation” in Rivas’ leadership team.

The changes, which go into effect Jan. 22, included removing Assemblyman Chris Holden, D-Pasadena, as Assembly Appropriations Committee chair in favor of Assemblywoman Buffy Wicks, D-Oakland, and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, in place of Assemblyman Phil Ting, D-San Francisco, as chair of the Assembly Budget Committee.

Wicks, in an email to supporters, vowed to use the powerful appropriations chair “to more effectively advocate for more affordable housing, better support for working families, and a more equitable future for all Californians.”

Rivas’ announcement also included the unusual decision to name outgoing Assemblyman Kevin McCarty, D-Sacramento, as chair of the Assembly Public Safety Committee. McCarty has chosen not to run for reelection, as he instead seeks to succeed Darrell Steinberg as mayor of Sacramento.

In a statement, McCarty said that the committee handles “many topics” that are “top of mind for Californians.”

“I look forward to moving balanced and common sense policies next year,” he said.

TROPICAL STORM HILARY A MAJOR DISASTER

President Joe Biden has formally declared Tropical Storm Hilary — which battered a large swath of California with high winds and rain — a major disaster. This unlocks Federal Emergency Management Agency funds to help pay for recovery efforts in parts of Imperial, Inyo, Kern, Riverside and Siskiyou counties, according to a statement from the Governor’s Office of Emergency Services.

“President Biden continues to stand with our state whenever disaster strikes. This declaration brings in more resources to support communities and rebuild critical public infrastructure,” Gov. Gavin Newsom said in a statement.

The August storm was one of the rare tropical storms to strike the Golden State, according to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Association.

“It is quite rare for a tropical storm or hurricane to maintain its strength and tropical characteristics in this part of the world, due to cool ocean waters and currents as well as prevailing trade winds that blow from east to west in this area,” NOAA said in a post about the storm.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

“At a time when California must be vigilant in protecting civil rights, fostering a just legal system, and ensuring everyday consumers are protected, it is an honor to serve as Chair of Judiciary Committee. Having served on this committee for the past seven years under Chairs Stone and Maienschein, I am grateful for their leadership and ready to hit the ground running.”

- Assemblyman Ash Kalra, D-San Jose, in a statement announcing his appointment as chair of the Assembly Judiciary Committee.

Best of The Bee:

California’s Department of Justice can continue to share firearm data with researchers studying the causes of gun violence, per a new court order, via Cathie Anderson.Gavin Newsom is still a rising political star, but his path to national prominence has gotten rocky as he heads into his debate with Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis next Thursday, via David Lightman.Millions of Latinos will gather for the holidays. Some will be shamed for their Spanish skills, via Mathew Miranda.The Sacramento Ethics Commission has determined there is insufficient evidence to support the allegation that City Councilwoman Katie Valenzuela violated city code in her first batch campaign funds, via Theresa Clift.

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